

Knee Replacement Recovery - Printable Sheets

From *Knee Replacement Recovery* by Margaret Hale (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

Your surgical team's instructions always take priority over anything on these sheets.

THE RED FLAG CARD

Cut this out and put it on the fridge. Fill in the numbers before the operation.

My surgical team	
Out of hours number	
My physiotherapist	
Operation date	

CALL AN AMBULANCE

Sudden breathlessness
Chest pain, worse on breathing in
Coughing up blood
Racing heart, faint, collapse

Say: "I had a knee replacement [x] days ago and I am short of breath."

RING THE TEAM THE SAME DAY

Possible infection	Possible clot
Pain increasing after the first	New or one-sided calf

few days	pain
Redness spreading from the wound	New calf swelling, different from usual
Increasing heat and hardness	Redness or warmth over the calf
Fluid, pus or bad smell	Calf hard or tight
Wound edge opening	
Fever, chills, feeling unwell	

Also: pain not controlled by your medication - unable to pass urine - a fall onto the knee - the knee giving way.

THE PREHAB PLAN - THE SIX WEEKS BEFORE

The most valuable sheet in this pack, and it only works beforehand. Ten minutes, twice a day.

Exercise	Reps	W1	W2	W3	W4	W5	W6
Quadriceps sets (hold 5 sec)							
Straight-leg raises							
Heel slides (the bend)							
Sit to stand, no hands							
Seated knee extensions							
Hamstring / calf stretch							
Arm strengthening							
Walking / cycling / pool	mins						

The rest of the preparation

	Done
Stopped smoking	

Dental check done	
Other conditions optimised (BP, diabetes, anaemia)	
Alcohol reduced	
Practised with crutches	
Practised the sleeping position	

THE HOME PREPARATION CHECKLIST

Do this **before**. Doing it afterwards on one leg is miserable.

The essentials	Done
A firm chair with arms, hips above knees	
Raised toilet seat and grab rail	
Shower stool, long-handled sponge, non-slip mat	
Rugs rolled up and put away , cables taped	
Walking routes cleared	
A trolley or rucksack (you cannot carry anything on a frame)	
Decided: upstairs or downstairs for sleeping	

The things people wish they had bought	Done
Long-handled grabber	

Long-handled shoehorn, slip-on shoes with a firm back	
Several ice packs , so one is always frozen	
A firm pillow for under the ankle (not the knee)	
Thermos or bottle with a lid	
Phone chargers by the chair and the bed	
Loose trousers that fit over a swollen knee	

Arrangements	Done
Someone with me for the first days	
Food cooked and frozen, or deliveries arranged	
Shopping, pets, bins, post arranged	
Everything daily moved to between waist and shoulder height	
People warned that weeks 3-6 are the	

hard ones	
Something to occupy me	

THE QUESTIONS FOR MY SURGEON

Question	Their answer
Why now, and what if I wait a year?	
Am I a candidate for a partial rather than a total?	
Given my age and activity, how long should this implant last?	
What anaesthetic do you recommend, and why?	
Will the kneecap be resurfaced?	
What is your protocol - weight-bearing, exercises, physio?	
How much bend do you expect at 6 weeks and 12?	
How long in hospital, realistically?	
What pain relief will I go home with, and for how long?	
What clot prevention, and for how long?	

When can I drive?	
When can I go back to my job? (describe it)	
When can I fly?	
What will I not be able to do afterwards?	
What should make me ring you, and what number?	
What do your patients most often wish they had known?	

THE WEEK-BY-WEEK RECOVERY TRACKER

This sheet exists for week five. When you are convinced nothing is improving, look back at week one. Memory in this period is unreliable and pessimistic.

Week	Pain /10	Painkillers per day	Walking distance	Aid used	Sleep /5	Mood /5	Something I can do now that I could not last week
1							
2							
3							
4							
5							
6							
7							
8							
9							
10							

11							
12							

THE BEND CHART

Ask your physiotherapist for the numbers at every visit and write them down. **A number you are tracking improves faster than a vague sense of progress.**

Date	Week	Flexion (bend)	Extension (straight)	Notes

Rough orientation - your surgeon's targets are the ones that count:

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~90 degrees	a right angle - normal chair, most stairs
~105-110	comfortable stairs, in and out of a car, a bicycle
115-120+	a good result

Extension matters as much as flexion. Never put a pillow under the knee - put it under the **ankle**.

If the bend is not improving between weeks 6 and 12, ring - do not wait for the next appointment.

THE MEDICATION TIMING SHEET

Take it **by the clock, not when it gets bad**. Staying ahead uses less medication than chasing.

Medicine	Dose	Times of day	Notes

Dose timed about an hour before physiotherapy:

Last dose of the day, timed to cover the night:

Clot prevention - finish date: _____ (take the **full** course even when you feel well)

Reducing the opioids

One dose at a time, daytime first, night dose last.

Week	Doses per day	Notes

Laxative started? _____ (constipation is near-universal - ask before it becomes a problem)

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